

Version control systems

Git and Mercurial are distributed version control systems, while SVN and CVS are centralised version control systems

Linux revision control

Git was created by Linus Torvalds for the Linux kernel as he found other systems unsuitable. The first 10 years of Linux development were un-versioned

A look at 7 popular code-hosting services

Just wrote some awesome code? Want to share it with the world? We explore the growing trend of online code-hosting services with a look at seven popular code-hosting sites.

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Introduction

Source code can get increasingly difficult to manage and collaborate without a revision control system is involved. Developers embarking on any serious project are likely to be using a revision control system, and the recent trend has been towards distributed revision control systems such as Mercurial and Git rather than the older CVS and SVN.

In addition to a repository, a software development project needs a bug tracking system as well. Hosting code in a central place, such that it is accessible by everyone involved is quite important, especially for open source projects.

A number of web sites have emerged recently that make sharing code online simple, and make it extremely simple to collaborate on. Many web sites have evolved into a sort of source-code-based social networking sites.

We take a look at some popular code-hosting services, and the services they offer.

SourceForge

SourceForge is possibly one of the most popular code-hosting web sites on the internet today. It hosts the largest number of projects and has the largest user base. SourceForge is owned Geeknet, Inc. the same people who are behind ThinkGeek and Slashdot.

Like many similar sites, SourceForge offers free hosting for Open Source projects. SourceForge provides many unique features such as shell access to your projects, and a MySQL database to power your web site or applications online. Project owners can run their own

CMS and host project information on SourceForge, allowing them to essentially host their entire project web site code and downloads on a single site for free. SourceForge is also unique in that it does not enforce any usage quotas on their projects, instead trusting their users to use this resource reasonably. SourceForge does not host closed-source software.

Suitable for:

- Open source projects
- Projects that need web hosting / blog / forum in addition to code hosting
- Projects that need flexibility in bug tracker, and wiki
- People who want shell access to their projects online

Google Code

Google provides free hosting for open source projects in its Google Code web site. It is used by Google for hosting its own open source projects such as the Chrome browser, Chrome OS, and other

open source tools and libraries. Similar to SourceForge, Google Code is for open source applications only.

Besides offering a repository for your project, Google Code also includes a Wiki, an Issue tracker, online source code browsing interface, and downloads for your project.

Google Code integrates with Google's other services such as Google accounts, for login, and Google Analytics for tracking downloads. Additionally, Google Code also includes some integration with Google Groups to help form discussions around a project.

Suitable for:

- Open source projects
- People working on Google projects or derivatives
- Those already using Google services and who prefer clean interfaces

GitHub

When it comes to hosting code managed using the Git revision control system, GitHub is the most popular of them all, and for good reason. GitHub offers a powerful social experience for coders that makes it incredibly easy to "fork" someone else's work to create your own derivative, and to merge projects with common goals.

Social Networking-like concepts such as following people / projects and getting status updates on your profile are employed by GitHub to make following



Among its vast bouquet of services is Google's 'Code'